

Vendor Coordination - State Office and Local Agency Roles/Responsibilities

Policy: The State WIC Office develops policies and procedures to authorize and monitor vendors in a way which ensures Program integrity. The State WIC Office works with Local WIC Agencies to coordinate vendor activities.

Regulation: 7 CFR 246.12

Procedure/Additional Guidance:

The State WIC Benefit Delivery Unit (BDU) is available to work with local agencies (LA) regarding matters that concern vendors. The State WIC fiscal staff and Nutrition Consultants can also assist LA WIC staff with vendor problems and/or questions.

State Office BDU Role and Responsibilities

- Work with vendors and Local Agency Retailer Coordinators (LARC) to foster positive working relationships.
- Develop policies and procedures to ensure consistency and accuracy in all efforts to promote Program integrity.
- Provide vendors and LARC with support and information. This includes providing timely data and training guidance, answering questions about the Colorado WIC Food List & Shopping Guide, etc.
- Provide guidance for LARC on enforcing policies and procedures.
- Authorize and reauthorize vendors to participate in the Program. Coordination of the application review, application processing, and resultant agreement.
- Provide training coordination for LA WIC staff and vendors.
- Work with LARC and vendors to resolve ongoing problems.
- Facilitate communication between State staff and LAs regarding vendor issues.
- Ensure Federal requirements for monitoring and compliance investigations are met.
- Enforce Federal regulations and initiate actions for sanctions against vendors who are in violation of the Program's policies and procedures.
- Provide general oversight of the vendor component of the Program.
- Participate on both the internal Allowable Foods List Committee and the Colorado WIC Allowable Foods List Advisory Committee to promote inclusive decision-making, understanding, and open, effective communication with external stakeholders.
- Assist vendors in obtaining payments for WIC transactions in conjunction with the Fiscal Unit.
- Maintain Vendor Management data tracking systems.
- Maintain the pricing system in conjunction with WIC Fiscal staff.
- Publish the WIC's WORLD newsletter.
- Conduct activities with local agencies—such as training sessions, quarterly conference calls, and one-on-one dialogue—to assist in the development of competencies in order to meet and exceed State objectives as outlined in the State Plan.
- Analyze processes to identify areas that can be improved to enhance Program integrity.
- Provide training material and reports to ensure information is useful, accurate, culturally and linguistically appropriate.
- Implement a vendor peer group system (i.e., grouping similar stores together), competitive price criteria, and allowable reimbursement levels to ensure, along with WIC Fiscal Unit, that the WIC Program pays authorized vendors competitive prices.

Local Agency Retailer Coordinator (LARC) Roles and Responsibilities

- Conduct pre-authorization, orientation, formal and informal monitoring visits to ensure compliance with Program policies and procedures. Document results by submitting accurate and completed reports to the BDU.
- Provide training for vendors and new WIC educators.
- Work with store personnel to handle questions about the Colorado WIC Food List & Shopping Guide, obtaining special formulas, ensuring minimum stocking requirements are met, and resolving ongoing vendor issues.

- Respond to and work to find resolution to participant/vendor complaints or issues and document complaints in vendor files or the MIS system.
- Report ongoing or serious vendor problems to the BDU for follow-up, including forwarding copies of written complaints to State WIC Benefit Delivery Unit Coordinator.
- Work with the BDU to develop procedures that address vendor problems.
- Enforce Federal regulations and Program policies and procedures that apply to vendors and participants consistently and accurately to ensure Program integrity.
- Communicate policy procedural changes to vendors and to other LA WIC staff.
- Participate in BDU's quarterly conference calls to facilitate communication between State staff and LAs regarding vendor issues, and program updates and changes.
- Recommend compliance investigations or inventory audits be conducted on vendors who may be (or suspected of being) in violation of the Program.
- Assist with disqualification/sanction implementation including, providing written documentation supporting the case against the vendor, testifying at Fair Hearing Procedures, etc.
- Provide general oversight of and point-of-contact for vendors within the service area.
- Work with the BDU on recommendations for the Colorado WIC Food List & Shopping Guide.
- Maintain a complete file on all vendors within the service area.
- Provide State WIC Program with feedback on participant training material and reports to ensure information is useful, accurate, culturally, and linguistically appropriate.
- Analyze processes to identify areas that can be improved to enhance Program integrity.
- Act as local agency expert in WIC Retailer Coordination, including knowledge of policies and procedures detailed in the WIC Vendor Handbook.
- Work with State WIC and with Local Agency Director/Management in the creation of processes to run and/or receive reports, enter any resulting appropriate violations in the Compass "Participants Violations" panel, alert staff to counsel participants at next appointment, counsel participant, and track notice of sanction.

Forms and reports (listed below) used by LARC to complete the LARC roles and responsibilities are available in the LARC Google Drive, including the following documents.

- Pre-Authorization Procedures Report.
- Retailer Routine Monitoring Procedures and Report.
- Other resources and documents.